

Zochreinu

237a

Version 4

Abraham Singer
Arr. Stuart Izon

Zochreinu Lachayim is the first of the four insertions to the Amida specifically for the period of Rosh Hashana to Yom Kippur. It is a succinct poem of only four lines, which each end with the word "life", and asks God to inscribe us in the Book of Life for the coming year.

This melody was written by Abraham Singer, and is almost certainly the best-known setting of zochreinu – though not in the form used in this arrangement. Singer's melody is far better known as a concert piece, sung mostly in Yiddish, with words about the High Holy Days rather than words for use during them. The version presented here is the same melody, but set to the correct liturgical text.

The Yiddish concert text is interspersed with the words zochreinu lachayim, as well as part of the vidui. It briefly nods to the kol nidrei melody, and closes with the phrase l'shana haba'a birushalayim. The full piece is considerably longer than this short piyut, with zochreinu lachayim returning as a refrain throughout. Notably, the actual liturgical line "l'ma'ancho elohim chayim" never appears in it. When the Yiddish setting is adapted for use on the High Holy Days, l'ma'ancho is typically sung melodically over the second half of the melody, giving an unbalanced number of words across the two phrases.

However, one of Singer's own notebooks (viewable online at the Cantorial and Synagogue Music Archive) preserves the correct liturgical text set to this same melody, with the words underlaid as per this arrangement, suggesting he did intend it for synagogue use on Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur. The notebook is undated, so it's hard to say for certain which version came first. But to my ear, this simpler synagogue setting fits the natural prosody of the words far more comfortably.

Adagio

Melody Alto

mp

Zoch - rei - nu la - cha - yim zoch - rei - nu la - cha - yim

Tenor Bass

4

M A

me - lech cha - fetz ba - cha - yim *mf* v' - chot - vei - nu b' - se - fer b' -

T B

Musical score for "Halleluyah" by George Frideric Handel. The score is for Soprano (S), Alto (A), and Tenor/Bass (T/B) voices, and a basso continuo (C). The lyrics are: "-se-fer ha-cha - yim l' - ma - an - cha e - lo - him__ cha - yim". The music is in G major and 2/4 time, with a tempo marking of "rit." (ritardando). The score includes a repeat sign and a final double bar line.